

5.3 PC: Getting the Hardware Right

PC gaming is all about having the right hardware. It can be the difference between having a good time and having a great time. And thanks to some cut-throat competition we're spoilt for choice! With prices falling constantly, buying a gaming rig no longer requires a pocket deep enough to fit a Grand Canyon. Let's see what type of hardware you need to look at, as a gamer.

5.31 Know you PC

Today, most games utilize almost every piece of hardware on your PC. From the motherboard to the soundcard, maybe even your Ethernet card! Let's take a look at the important components.

Processor

The most basic piece of equipment you will find in your computer is the processor. Quite literally it's the brain of the computer, and can do calculations at the speed of light. Processors have come a long way from the early days of the 486 systems. Gone are the days when 133 MHz processors were called blazingly fast. Today processors have breached the 3.0 GHz mark and show no signs of stopping. And that's not even taking into account 64-bit processors which are even faster!

In a game, the processor plays a major role. There are thousands of calculations and computations that need to be done every second. For e.g. Every movement you make and how it affects the environment around you, your interaction with the environment, the behavior of the AI and so on. All of this is done by the processor. Naturally a faster processor is very helpful, but its effectiveness depends on the rest of the hardware too.

Motherboard

The motherboard is like a switchboard at a telephone exchange. It connects the various hardware components. Every component is either directly or indirectly connected to it. It has a number of slots where you can plug in your hardware. These slots can either be of the PCI, PCI-E, AGP or IDE variety, apart from which you also